

INFANTRY ARMOUR AND WEAPONS

At the start of the Middle Ages, foot soldiers, armed with spears and axes, played an important role on the battlefield. They were gradually marginalized as mounted knights became the dominant military force, but enjoyed a resurgence after the 13th century with the development of staff weapons such as pollaxes and bills (billhooks), which gave them a longer reach and enabled them to keep horsemen at bay. At Courtrai in 1302, a Flemish army of townspeople and peasants, armed with *godendags* (long-hafted staff weapons with a spike), defeated a French army of feudal cavalry, marking the beginning of a new golden age of infantry.

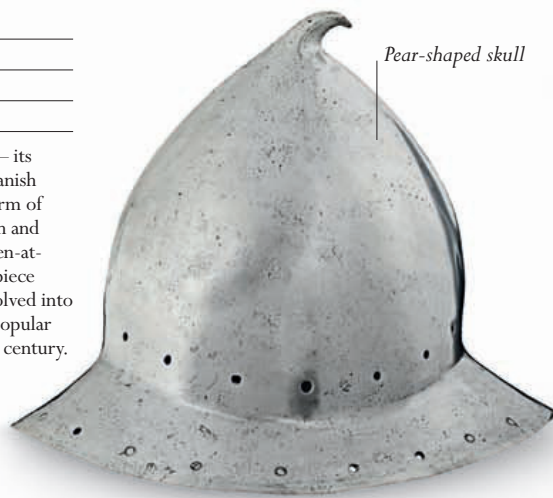
► CAPACETE

Date c.1470

Origin Spain

Material Steel

The capacete (or cabasset) – its name deriving from the Spanish *cabeza*, or “head” – was a form of “kettle” hat worn by Spanish and Portuguese infantry and men-at-arms. It had a conical headpiece and a narrow brim, and evolved into the “Spanish” morion, the popular infantry helmet of the 16th century.



▲ BRIGANDINE

Date Early 16th century

Origin Europe

Material Canvas, velvet, steel

The brigandine became very popular among foot soldiers in bands of condottieri (mercenaries) in the 15th and 16th centuries. It was a light armour of canvas and steel plates, often covered with rich material (in this case, crimson velvet, which has largely perished).

Blade narrow at base



▲ BEARDED AXE

Date 900–1100

Origin Denmark

Weight (Blade) 785g (27½oz)

Axes of this period had broad blades – as long as 30cm (12in) – that could inflict terrible injuries. In Scandinavia, where this example was found, a hero's weapon might earn a bloodthirsty name, such as “Wound's Wolf”.

Long wooden shaft

Wide curved cutting edge

Tapered shaft for a tight fit



▼ POLLAXE

Date 1470

Origin France

Length (Head) 32cm (12½in)

The pollaxe had multiple blades: the spike for thrusting, the axe blade for cutting through armour, and the hammer head for crushing tissue and bones. It was used both by pure infantry and, from around 1350, by knights fighting on foot.

Honed cutting edge

Fluke or spur

◀ BILL

Date Late 15th century

Origin England

Weight (Head) 2.3kg (5lb)

Length (Head) 49cm (19¼in)

Developed from the rural labourer's billhook, the bill was used from the 10th to the 16th centuries. The spikes and flukes made it an effective parrying weapon. This example has two triangular spikes and a short triangular fluke.

Triangular spike

